

Dolby believes theatres matter

Is it the Upgrade Indian Moviegoers Actually Need?

Siddharth Chauhan | editor@digit.in

India loves a spectacle and among the sheer number of ways to watch a movie right now, we already have IMAX stretching the canvas, ScreenX wrapping content around our peripheral vision and 4DX turning our seats into amusement park rides. Now, Dolby, after testing the waters with screens in Pune and Bengaluru, has launched its premier format, Dolby Cinema, at Allu Cinemas in Hyderabad.

I sat down with Ashim Mathur, VP of Marketing for Dolby Laboratories across Asia Pacific, to figure out what sets their flagship theatre experience apart from the standard, everyday multiplex screens.

I also spoke to Allu Aravind, the veteran producer and exhibitor who made the call to install this screen and shared the evolution of screens he has witnessed albeit what the future of film viewing means.

Taking a step back. Last time I spoke to Mathur, he spoke about Dolby's mission. "Our mission," he said, "is to unlock the power of sight and sound to create spectacular experiences."

When I met Mathur again on the sidelines of the new Dolby Cinema screen opening, I wanted to know if this

was going to be a tangible upgrade to the movie-watching experience. If Dolby was truly "unlocking" something about sight and sound, the proof had to be somewhere on that screen.

How is Dolby Cinema Different?

According to Mathur, Hyderabad now features a state-of-the-art Dolby Cinema experience and at 75 feet wide it is India's largest Dolby Cinema screen with 644 seats housed in a space that's meant to strip away distractions and max out the audio-visual fidelity.

"When you go to a Dolby Cinema, you see a really different design," Mathur told me, adding, "Each seat will give you the best experience wherever you are. The way it is designed, the way it is kind of done up, it's really black. All the speakers are concealed.

You don't see where the speakers are and where the sound is coming from."

Any fan of The Big Bang Theory will remember Sheldon Cooper's near-religious relationship with finding the acoustic sweet spot in a theatre

because the audio was perfect from precisely that point. For purists, it's also a real anxiety they carry into every hall. Is the screen too close? Too far? Will I hear the left channel more than the right?

This Dolby Cinema system runs on dual Dolby 6P laser projectors pushing a combined 22,000 watts of output via 72 speakers and supports 3D too. Dolby Vision delivers what the company calls ultra-vivid colour and a full contrast ratio and the demo clips made this viscerally clear. Combine that with the precision object-based audio of Dolby Atmos and the experience is dialled up to a t.

"When it comes with that immersiveness from a viewing perspective coupled with Dolby Atmos," Mathur notes, "I think that's where it creates a powerhouse of experience."

Allu Aravind is unambiguous about why he chose Dolby over every other format on the market. "In all the formats I've seen, Dolby Cinema particularly marries the sound and visuals so well and it gives a great experience. That is the reason I chose Dolby." Coming from someone who's seen every premium format pitch, that's not an endorsement for the sake of it.

The first thing we watched was the 3D trailer of Ramayana. The combination of Dolby Vision's contrast and the dual-projector 3D gave each frame a structural depth and when Hans Zimmer and A.R. Rahman's score kicked in through the Atmos system, the sound didn't feel like coming from point sources and instead the hall was engulfed with the music. **d**



Allu Aravind
Veteran Producer and Exhibitor



Ashim Mathur
Vice President of Marketing for Dolby Laboratories across Asia Pacific

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